

Recognize it

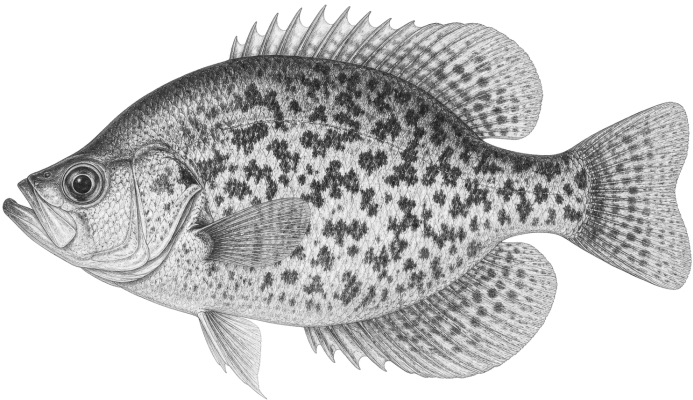
Deep, compressed silver-olive panfish with irregular dark speckles scattered across the sides.

Body	Seven or eight dorsal spines; mottling has no orderly vertical bars.
Mouth/fins	Large upturned mouth; dorsal and anal fins are nearly equal in outline.
Confusion	White crappie usually shows vertical bars and five or six dorsal spines.

Lake role

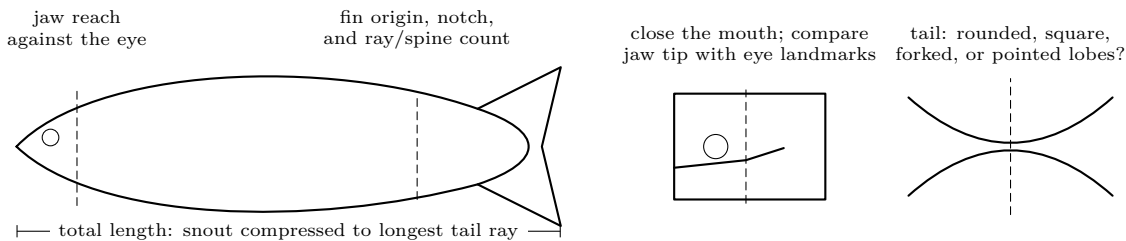
Where it belongs Clear-water weeds, wood, basin edges, and suspended schools near prey.
Food and season Insects and small fish; shallow near spawning cover, then edge or suspend.

Identification plate



Original graphite portrait for this ChatGPT edition. Morphology reviewed against Wisconsin DNR species references.

Read the fish before naming it



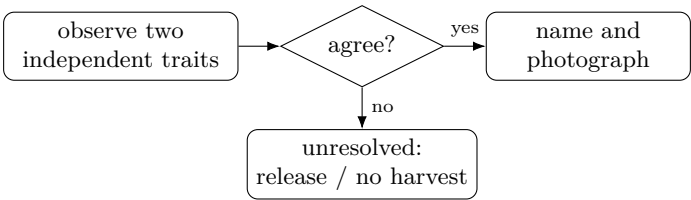
- 1. **Silhouette first.** Confirm a deep, compressed body and compare the nearly mirrored dorsal and anal outlines.
- 2. **Hard structure second.** Count seven or eight dorsal spines; do not infer the count from mottling.
- 3. **Markings last.** Look for scattered, irregular speckles rather than ordered vertical bars.

Intermediate questions

Before looking at the species name, answer aloud: *Where does the closed jaw end? Are dorsal sections joined or separate? What is the tail-lobe shape? Which mark is structural enough to survive poor light?* If two answers conflict, record “unresolved” and do not force the identification.

Confusion-pair gate

Candidate	Black Crappie
Nearest alternative	White crappie usually shows vertical bars and five or six dorsal spines.
Required gate	Call black crappie only when the irregular spotting and seven/eight-spine dorsal agree.
Independent check	Check the large upturned mouth and near-equal dorsal/anal profiles in a lateral photograph.



Find it on these waters

Pine	Test protected new weeds in spring; later scan outside weed edges and open-water prey.
North	Test wood, weed pockets, and the first break near protected spawning water.
Evidence	The DNR lake records sometimes name only a broad group such as panfish. In that case this species is a candidate member, not verified individual presence. Confirm presence before targeting; treat locations as testable habitat hypotheses, not abundance findings.

Field evidence log

Date/time	Water + station	Depth/temp	Two observed traits	Habitat, lure, result
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Evidence threshold. One sighting is an observation, not an abundance claim. Repeat the same identification gate on another fish, retain a clear lateral photograph when lawful and safe, and note failed searches as carefully as catches. A repeat catch at the same suspended depth supports a school; a lone fish does not.

Presentations

1. **Slip float.** Hang a small jig or live bait just above marked fish; adjust depth before changing color.
2. **Slow vertical jig.** Use a light plastic or hair jig and pause; keep it above the school.
3. **Stop rule.** If no marks, bites, or bait appear in ten minutes, move and search rather than decorating empty water.

On-water verification
After the first response, ask: <i>Did the fish, depth, cover, and bite match the prediction?</i> Repeat once. If the second result disagrees, return to search mode rather than explaining away the evidence.

HANDLING DECIDES THE OUTCOME
Use wet hands and a small rubber net. Support the body; do not lift a large fish by the lip alone.

Harvest decision · 2026–27

Water-specific rule	Open all year; no minimum; panfish daily bag 25 on both lakes as listed 2026-07-26.
Kitchen choice	Prefer abundant hand-size fish; release unusually large adults if a meal is already secured.
Before the trip	Open the Wisconsin DNR water-specific regulation page for WBIC 779200 (Pine) or 850800 (North). Check the exact water, species, and date; the live rule controls if this dated sheet differs.

Keep only a fish you can use
Decide before the cast. Bring ice, stop fishing when the planned meal is secured, and use the species-specific cooking guide for dispatch, bone layout, and safe preparation. Large old predators are valuable spawners and generally carry more mercury than smaller fish.

Sources checked 2026-07-26. Wisconsin DNR lake fish records (Pine WBIC 779200; North WBIC 850800), Wisconsin’s Fishes, Hook Your Catch, 2026–27 water-specific regulations, Catch-and-release Guidelines, and Eating Your Catch. Biological and tactical synthesis is editorial; it is not a current population survey.

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